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THE COMEBACK NO ONE SAW COMING

From 104 points down to within striking distance, defending champion Max Verstappen's relentless recovery leaves Abu Dhabi poised for a **dramatic finale.**

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For the last few years, Formula One has almost felt predictable: one dominant driver at the front, heritage teams cycling through familiar patterns, and results that rarely surprised. The opening of 2025 looked only slightly different. A team on a redemption arc, past winners struggling, old midfield woes fading, and most races split between just two drivers. But F1 never stays still for long. In a sport defined by shifting dynamics and razor-thin margins, the moment you think you know the script is exactly when the story changes. Over the past few weekends, the series has given new, urgent meaning to the old phrase — it's never over until it's over. And the one driver who has etched those words into the minds of millions? Max Verstappen.

Just seven races — roughly three months — ago, the defending champion trailed Oscar Piastri by a seemingly unbridgeable 104 points. Yet an almost unthinkable sequence of events has seen him overhaul the Australian and stand just 12 points away from a fifth consecutive crown.

It has been an inconceivable comeback that few dared to imagine, and even fewer believed could actually unfold. But Verstappen did, as he always does. He is never a driver you can count out, and his hard-fought wins in Las Vegas and Qatar only reaffirmed his superiority.

And now, for the second time in his storied career, he arrives in Abu Dhabi — the final

Too good: Red Bull's pace and strategy proved flawless, as Verstappen won the Qatar Grand Prix. GETTY IMAGES